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# Welcome!

*Thanksgiving Special: A Lib Guide* investigates the historical and ongoing role of the heroic national origin myth that is Thanksgiving

# Introduction

What were you taught about thanksgiving?

“Thanksgiving Special: A Lib Guide” explores the mythical history of Thanksgiving and its importance in constructing and reinforcing social cohesion at the macro-level of the nation. Moreover, zooming in on the individual micro-level, it is our hope to guide students in an examination of the physic toll of settler anxieties (resistance, repression, deflection) in relation to the holiday. Throughout, this resource guide takes up the history of the Thanksgiviing tradition and defines settler colonialism, all while aiming to understand Indigenous perspectives (The National Day of Mourning) and the ideological operations of whiteness and tradition in America.

Ultimately, the value of our research guide lies in its aim to broaden the narrative around a holiday that is often drowned out by the noise of false histories and contemporary societies’ instantaneous consumerism.

# Structure

Where to look first?

This guide is structured by subtopic, or collections, under the Knowledge tab. There you will find each topic and a list of featured recommended readings, as well as a short explanation of each collection. Click on the link to read the resource, or head over to the index page to discover related search terms and to learn more about subsequent themes of interest for further research. At the end will be a list of recommended databases that users can use to dig a little deeper into a topic on their own.

## Library Contacts



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| The Project | Context | Further Resources |
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# The Project

“Thanksgiving Special: A Lib Guide” is a library guide that serves our university library, an institution that welcomes the surrounding community of high schoolers, undergraduates, and those that make up their lives. The history behind Thanksgiving can at times be dense, challenging material, oftentimes not only in its educational rigor but in its difficult regognitions. Despite this, it is our hope that this guide broadens the educational and informational scope of a topic caught up in a project of national myth-making and civic religion. In an effort to give an alternative and more honest look at this beloved and notable holiday, please read on.

# Context

Underpinning this research Guide is an examination of the historical genesis, transformations, and contemporary implications of myth and tradition on American culture and society. The lack of an encounter with this past, on a history that bares almost no relation to how we remember it, reinscribes the truamas and the guilt on the minds of the living. Hence, in an effort for the creation of new possibilities, this library guide seeks to address a younger audience inclined to learn more about settler colonial histories in an American context, as well as its relation to the Thanksgiving holiday.

# Further Resources

What’s a lib guide anyway?

Here there exists links to other lib guides to help you come to grips with what a lib guide is, especially as it relates to similar topics of exploration:

[AMCULT 203: Early American Cultural History](#)

[The Library Research Process, Step-by-Step](#)

[United States History History \(General\)](#)

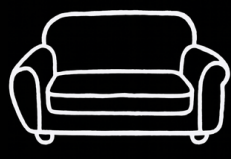
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Databases

These Collections hold an inventory of resources on the following topics:  
The Traditons of Thanksgiving; Commercialization & the Culture of Consumption;  
Defining settler colonialism; Indigenous Perspectives;  
The Holiday Syndrome; and The Ritual Meal & Social Cohesion.



### Tradition of Thanksgiving

The Proclamation of the First Thanksgiving on June 20, 1676 had the American colonialist thanking God for their good fortune in settling in America, as well as the disappointment and destruction of their enemies. Additionally, the National Thanksgiving Proclamation by George Washington established November 26 as a national day of public thanksgiving and prayer.

[Proclamation of the first Thanksgiving, 1676](#)

[Thanksgiving Proclamation of 1789](#)

[Customization of U.S. Holidays: Agency and Nonconformity](#)

[Abraham Lincoln Thanksgiving Proclamation, 1863](#)

[Pilgrims and Puritans and the Myth of the Promised Land](#)

[Pumpkin: The Curious History of an American Icon](#)



### Commercialization & the Culture of Consumption

Thanksgiving has increasingly been commercialized, starting in the latter half of the 19th century and continuing on to today. Original traditions, which were already problematic, were phased out in favor of new or altered ones more conducive to a capitalist society. Today, the act of consuming vast quantities of food, to indulge in bottomless need, acts as a celebration of America’s overabundance.

[The Commercialization of the Calendar: American Holidays and the Culture of Consumption, 1870-1930](#)

[“We Gather Together”: Consumption Rituals of Thanksgiving Day](#)

[Beware Of Post-Thanksgiving ‘Brown Friday’ AKA Plumbers’ Busiest Day Of The Year](#)

[God, games and national glory: thanksgiving and the ritual of sport in American culture](#)



### Defining Settler Colonialism

Thanksgiving is a national holiday that is rooted in a settler colonial history. But what does that mean? It is oftentimes associated with the Pilgrims and their harvest meal with the American indigenous peoples. This perspective not only ignores the rupturing traumas that indigenous peoples went through (dispossession of their land, cultural erasure, and mass death), but also fails to view the violence as a structure, as a paradigm for economic and state formation. The following articles discuss the term settler colonialism, providing a brief survey of its implications.

[Settler Colonialism and the Elimination of the Native](#)

[Settler Colonialism: A Theoretical Overview](#)

[All the Real Indians Died Off: And 20 Other Myths about Native Americans](#)

[An Indigenous Peoples’ History of the United States](#)

[Mahmood Mamdani’s lecture, “Settler Colonialism, Then and Now”](#)



### Indigenous Perspectives

The currents of a white nationalists ideology ripple through the political, cultural, and economic developments of our country—a product of the centuries. An ultimate counterpoint to this traditional understanding of Thanksgiving is the perspective of indigenous peoples. Such perspectives expose the mythic origins of the holiday, but also furnish additional perspectives about the activity of giving thanks. The following links discuss counter-memories and indigenous activism, or resistance.

[This Land is Their Land: The Wampanoag Indians, Plymouth Colony, and the Troubled History of Thanksgiving](#)

[United American Indians of New England National Day of Mourning Homepage](#)

[Red Nation podcas, “National Day of Mourning: 400 years of genocide and resistance”](#)

[Indigenous Continent: The Epic Contest for North America](#)

[Lakota Historian Nick Estes on Thanksgiving](#)



### The Holiday Syndrome

The Holidays should be a happy moment of the year for most people, but there are some for whom that is not the case. The Holiday Syndrome is when a person’s mental health is stressed out, caused by factors that happen during busy holidays like Thanksgiving, Christmas, and New Year’s. The following links give a psychoanalytic look at this phenomenon, arguing that the traditions and norms of the holidays can cause a regression into childhood for susceptible patients

[The Holiday Syndrome](#)

[HOLIDAY, SYMPTOM AND DREAM](#)

[The Psychodynamics of the “HOLIDAY SYNDROME”](#)



### The Ritual Meal & Social Cohesion

The Thanksgiving rituals of performative thankfulness and the obligatory meal are methods of socializing that increase the social cohesion of American society. The comparatively lavish meals that marines had on Thanksgiving in the past (USS Augusta 1942 Thanksgiving Day Dinner), compared to their normally rationed meals, are one example. Additionally, media companies like the Centron Corporation sought to form the opinions of the American youth through programming such as “A Day of Thanksgiving” (1951), where a family extolls the virtues of the American values the holiday represented.

[A Day of Thanksgiving, 1951](#)

[USS Augusta 1942 Thanksgiving Day Dinner](#)

[“We Gather Together” Food and Festival in American Life](#)

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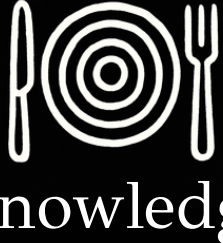
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Databases

Index is a dynamic directory of everything Thanksgiving

| TITLE                                                                                                                     | CONTRIBUTIONS                           | Search Terms                                                                                      | Collection                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">A Day of Thanksgiving, 1951</a>                                                                               | Centron Corporation                     | <div>Patriotism</div> <div>Social Roles</div> <div>Thankfulness</div>                             | The Ritual Meal & Social Cohesion          |
| <a href="#">Pumpkin: The Curious History of an American Icon</a>                                                          | Cindy Ott                               | <div>Holiday Foods</div> <div>Cultural history</div> <div>National identity</div>                 | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">This Land is Their Land: The Wampanoag Indians, Plymouth Colony, and the Troubled History of Thanksgiving</a> | David J. Silverman                      | <div>Wampanoags</div> <div>Ousamequin</div> <div>Pequot War</div>                                 | Indigenous Perspectives                    |
| <a href="#">Lakota Historian Nick Estes on Thanksgiving</a>                                                               | Democracy Now!                          | <div>Indigenous Resistance</div> <div>Indigenous Futures</div> <div>Occupation</div>              | Indigenous Perspectives                    |
| <a href="#">Thanksgiving Proclamation of 1789</a>                                                                         | George Washington                       | <div>Proclamation</div> <div>Thanksgiving</div> <div>Constitutional Government</div>              | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">Pilgrims and Puritans and the Myth of the Promised Land</a>                                                   | Heike Paul                              | <div>Puritan ideology</div> <div>Pilgrims</div> <div>Plymouth Colony</div>                        | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">HOLIDAY, SYMPTOM AND DREAM</a>                                                                                | Jean Rosenbaum                          | <div>Holiday neurosis</div> <div>dream analysis</div> <div>Freud</div>                            | The Holiday Syndrome                       |
| <a href="#">The Holiday Syndrome</a>                                                                                      | J.P. Catell                             | <div>Holiday anxiety</div> <div>Family conflict dynamics</div> <div>Resistance and guilt</div>    | The Holiday Syndrome                       |
| <a href="#">Red Nation podcasts, “National Day of Mourning: 400 years of genocide and resistance”</a>                     | Kisha James and Mahtowin Munro          | <div>Day of Mourning</div> <div>Pilgrim mythology</div> <div>Indigenous activism</div>            | Indigenous Perspectives                    |
| <a href="#">Settler Colonialism: A Theoretical Overview</a>                                                               | L. Veracini                             | <div>Screen memory</div> <div>Non-encounter</div> <div>Primal scene</div>                         | Defining Settler Colonialism               |
| <a href="#">The Commercialization of the Calendar: American Holidays and the Culture of Consumption, 1870-1930</a>        | Leigh Eric Schmidt                      | <div>Retail history</div> <div>Commodification</div> <div>Holiday calendar</div>                  | Commercialization & Culture of Consumption |
| <a href="#">Mahmood Mamdani’s lecture, “Settler Colonialism, Then and Now”</a>                                            | Mahmood Mamdani                         | <div>Political Economy</div> <div>Nativism</div> <div>Exogenous others</div>                      | Defining Settler Colonialism               |
| <a href="#">Proclamation of the first Thanksgiving, 1676</a>                                                              | Massachusetts Bay Colony                | <div>Proclamation</div> <div>Thanksgiving</div> <div>God</div>                                    | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">“We Gather Together”: Consumption Rituals of Thanksgiving Day</a>                                             | Melanie Wallendorf                      | <div>Ritual feasting</div> <div>Abundance</div> <div>Cultural icons</div>                         | Commercialization & Culture of Consumption |
| <a href="#">USS Augusta 1942 Thanksgiving Day Dinner</a>                                                                  | NHHC                                    | <div>WW2</div> <div>opposing forces</div> <div>divine providence</div>                            | The Ritual Meal & Social Cohesion          |
| <a href="#">Settler Colonialism and the Elimination of the Native</a>                                                     | Patrick Wolfe                           | <div>Settler Colonialism</div> <div>Indigenous dispossession</div> <div>Structural Violence</div> | Defining Settler Colonialism               |
| <a href="#">Indigenous Continent: The Epic Contest for North America</a>                                                  | Pekka Hämäläinen                        | <div>Indigenous power</div> <div>Indigenous empires</div> <div>Indigenous diplomacy</div>         | Indigenous Perspectives                    |
| <a href="#">Abraham Lincoln Thanksgiving Proclamation, 1863</a>                                                           | President Lincoln                       | <div>Deliverance</div> <div>Civil War</div> <div>Observance</div>                                 | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">Customization of U.S. Holidays: Agency and Nonconformity</a>                                                  | Robert M. Carini                        | <div>Rituals</div> <div>Resistance</div> <div>Leisure</div>                                       | Traditions of Thanksgiving                 |
| <a href="#">All the Real Indians Died Off: And 20 Other Myths about Native Americans</a>                                  | Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz                    | <div>Decolonization</div> <div>Stereotypes</div> <div>Land rights</div>                           | Defining Settler Colonialism               |
| <a href="#">An Indigenous Peoples’ History of the United States</a>                                                       | Roxanne Dunbar-Ortiz                    | <div>Indigenous genocide</div> <div>Militarization</div> <div>Imperialism</div>                   | Defining Settler Colonialism               |
| <a href="#">The Psychodynamics of the “HOLIDAY SYNDROME”</a>                                                              | Sarah Mullooly Sattin                   | <div>holiday anxiety</div> <div>psychodynamics</div> <div>transference</div>                      | The Holiday Syndrome                       |
| <a href="#">God, games and national glory: thanksgiving and the ritual of sport in American culture</a>                   | Steven W. Pope                          | <div>Civic Religion</div> <div>Nationalism</div> <div>Spectacle</div>                             | Commercialization & Culture of Consumption |
| <a href="#">“We Gather Together” Food and Festival in American Life</a>                                                   | Theodore C. Humphrey<br>Lin T. Humphrey | <div>Foodways</div> <div>Family folklore</div> <div>Festival</div>                                | The Ritual Meal & Social Cohesion          |
| <a href="#">United American Indians of New England National Day of Mourning Homepage</a>                                  | UAINE                                   |                                                                                                   | Indigenous Perspectives                    |

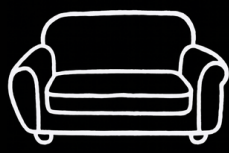
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Databases



Archive of Americana

<https://www.readex.com/products/archive-americana>

This database is a comprehensive collection of specifically American resources that shed light on its history and culture. Many primary source documents about Thanksgiving are available here.

Proquest

<https://www.proquest.com/index>

A search engine that will let you search over 100 databases for dissertations/theses, books, articles, archives, etc. Using Boolean operators along with pertinent search terms like “Thanksgiving” and “alternative perspectives” will give pertinent results



Google Scholar

<https://scholar.google.com/>

A free search engine/database that allows access to the full text of scholarly literature, including peer-reviewed articles, books, theses/dissertations, etc. Using the search terms “thanksgiving,” “history,” and “settler colonialism” will give you pertinent results.

PEP-Web Psychoanalytic Library

<https://pep-web.org/>

A database that houses countless examples of academic psychoanalytic research. Use this database for the psychology behind the ideas of Thanksgiving.



Institutes & Museums

**AQUINNAH CULTURAL CENTER**  
WAMPANOAG HISTORY MUSEUM

Providing Cultural Education and Tribal Engagement.

Learn the history of the Aquinnah Wampanoag through the contents of our museum, the voices of our community, and cultural events for both tribal members and the general public.

**Aquinnah Cultural Center**  
Aquinnah Cultural Center

**Historic Patuxet Homesite**  
Learn about the 17th-century culture and lifeways of Wampanoag People at the Historic Patuxet Homesite.  
Plimoth Patuxet Museums

**PILGRIM HALL MUSEUM**

**Home**  
Encounter the 400-year-old story of the Mayflower Pilgrims and the Indigenous Wampanoag people in the world's most significant Plymouth Colony collection.  
Pilgrim Hall Museum /

**Pilgrim Hall Museum**

**Gilder Lehrman Institute of American History**  
Homepage  
gilderlehrman.org

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